

IELTS Writing Task 2 — Complete Guide

From Agree / Disagree to every essay type: structures, model answers, band-9 language and a proven step-by-step method.

Opinion Essays

Discussion Essays

Problem-Solution

Advantages / Disadvantages

Two-Part Questions

10 Model Essays

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EMERALD LAB TIP

Work through the chapters in order the first time you read this book — each essay type builds on skills from the previous one. After that, use the Table of Contents to jump straight to the essay type you are practising.

How to Use This Book

A short guide before you begin

This handbook was built by **Emerald Lab** to take you from understanding the IELTS Writing Task 2 exam to confidently producing a Band 7-9 essay, whatever question type you are given. Every chapter follows the same simple pattern:

1. **What it is** — how to recognise the essay type from the question wording.
2. **The structure** — a paragraph-by-paragraph template you can rely on under exam pressure.
3. **Useful language** — phrases and linkers that fit that essay type naturally.
4. **Two model essays** — full Band 8-9 sample answers with brief notes.

STUDY METHOD

Read the structure, then cover the model essay and try writing your own answer to the same question in 40 minutes. Only after that, compare your essay with the model. This is far more effective than simply reading model answers passively.

All five essay types you will meet in the real IELTS exam are covered: **Opinion, Discussion, Problem-Solution, Advantages/Disadvantages**, and **Two-Part Questions**. The book begins with Opinion (Agree/Disagree) essays, since this is the most frequently tested type and the foundation for the rest.

Introduction to IELTS Writing Task 2

Format, timing and how your essay is marked

1.1 The Task in Brief

In Writing Task 2 you are given a topic and a viewpoint, argument or problem. You must write at least **250 words** in about **40 minutes**, presenting a clear, well-organised argument supported by relevant examples and reasons. Task 2 carries more weight than Task 1 in your final Writing score, so it deserves more of your time and attention.

1.2 The Five Question Types

Type	Typical Wording
Opinion (Agree/Disagree)	"To what extent do you agree or disagree?"
Discussion	"Discuss both views and give your own opinion."
Problem-Solution	"What problems does this cause and what solutions can you suggest?"
Advantages/Disadvantages	"What are the advantages and disadvantages of this?"
Two-Part Question	"Why is this the case? What can be done about it?"

1.3 How Your Essay Is Scored

Examiners assess your essay against four criteria, each worth 25% of your Writing score:

THE FOUR BAND CRITERIA

- **Task Response** — Did you fully answer the question with a clear position and relevant, developed ideas?
- **Coherence & Cohesion** — Is the essay logically organised into paragraphs, with clear linking between ideas?
- **Lexical Resource** — Is your vocabulary varied, precise and used naturally (not repeated or forced)?
- **Grammatical Range & Accuracy** — Do you use a mix of simple and complex sentences with few errors?

1.4 The Universal Essay Skeleton

Whatever the question type, almost every strong Task 2 essay follows this four- or five-paragraph shape:

STANDARD STRUCTURE

Paragraph 1 — Introduction: paraphrase the question, then state your thesis/position or preview your answer.

Paragraph 2 — Body 1: one main idea, explained and supported with an example.

Paragraph 3 — Body 2: a second main idea (or the second view/solution), explained and supported.

Paragraph 4 — Conclusion: summarise your position in different words; no new ideas here.

1.5 Timing Plan (40 Minutes)

- **3-5 min** — Read the question carefully, decide your position, plan your paragraphs.
- **30-32 min** — Write the essay, following your plan.
- **3-5 min** — Check grammar, spelling, word count and paragraphing.

Opinion (Agree / Disagree) Essays

The most common Task 2 question type

2.1 What It Is

You are given a statement and asked *"To what extent do you agree or disagree?"* You must give a clear opinion — either fully agree, fully disagree, or partly agree — and defend it with reasons and examples throughout the essay.

2.2 Choosing Your Position

Approach	When to use it
One-sided (fully agree/disagree)	When you can think of two strong, distinct reasons for one side — usually the safest, clearest choice under time pressure.
Balanced (partly agree)	When the statement genuinely has merit on both sides and you want to show nuance — still needs a clear final position.

2.3 Paragraph Structure

TEMPLATE — ONE-SIDED ESSAY

Intro: paraphrase + clear thesis ("I completely agree that...")

Body 1: Reason 1 + explanation + example

Body 2: Reason 2 + explanation + example

Conclusion: restate opinion + brief summary of reasons

2.4 Useful Language

Function	Phrases
Giving opinion	I firmly believe that... / In my view... / It seems to me that...
Adding reasons	Firstly... / What is more... / Equally important is the fact that...
Giving examples	For instance... / A clear illustration of this is... / Take, for example...
Concluding	In conclusion... / Taking everything into account...

MODEL ESSAY 1 — ONE-SIDED (AGREE)

Some people believe that unpaid community service should be a compulsory part of high school programmes. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

It is sometimes argued that secondary school students should be required to complete unpaid community service as part of their studies. I completely agree with this view, for reasons of both personal development and social benefit.

To begin with, compulsory volunteering teaches skills that a traditional classroom rarely can. When teenagers organise a food drive or assist at a care home, they learn responsibility, teamwork and time-management in a real-world setting rather than a theoretical one. A recent survey of British secondary schools found that students who had completed structured volunteering reported greater confidence in communication and problem-solving than those who had not, precisely because they had been forced out of their comfort zone.

Furthermore, mandatory service brings clear benefits to the wider community that voluntary schemes often fail to achieve, simply because far fewer students choose to take part unless required. Hospitals, environmental projects and elderly care homes frequently rely on younger volunteers to cover tasks that paid staff do not have time for. If every student contributed even twenty hours a year, the cumulative impact on local communities would be substantial, while students themselves would develop a lasting habit of civic engagement that many continue into adulthood.

In conclusion, I strongly support making community service compulsory in high schools, since it equips students with practical life skills while providing meaningful support to local communities.

MODEL ESSAY 2 — ONE-SIDED (DISAGREE)

In many countries, the amount of crime is increasing. Some people believe that harsher punishments are the only way to reduce crime. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Rising crime rates have led many people to call for tougher sentencing as the sole solution. I disagree with this position, believing instead that addressing the root causes of crime is a far more effective long-term strategy.

Admittedly, harsher penalties can act as a deterrent for some potential offenders and provide the public with a sense of justice. However, evidence from countries with the strictest sentencing laws,

such as parts of the United States, shows that severe punishment alone does not correlate with lower crime rates. This suggests that punishment addresses the symptom rather than the underlying disease.

A more effective approach lies in tackling the social and economic conditions that drive people towards crime in the first place, such as poverty, unemployment and lack of education. Countries like Norway have achieved remarkably low reoffending rates by investing heavily in rehabilitation, vocational training and mental health support for prisoners, rather than relying purely on lengthy sentences. This demonstrates that when former offenders are given genuine opportunities to reintegrate into society, they are far less likely to commit further crimes than those released with no such support.

In conclusion, while stricter punishments may offer a short-term sense of security, I believe that investing in prevention and rehabilitation is a considerably more sustainable way to reduce crime in the long run.

Discussion (Discuss Both Views) Essays

Presenting two sides fairly before giving your opinion

3.1 What It Is

You are given two opposing views on a topic and asked to "discuss both views and give your own opinion." Unlike the Opinion essay, you must give genuine, balanced coverage to both sides before stating which you personally favour.

3.2 Paragraph Structure

TEMPLATE

Intro: paraphrase the debate + state that you will discuss both views, then give your opinion

Body 1: explain View A fairly, with an example

Body 2: explain View B fairly, with an example (this is where your own opinion is usually developed further)

Conclusion: restate your opinion, briefly weighing both sides

COMMON MISTAKE

Do not ignore one side to argue only for your own opinion — you will lose marks for Task Response. Give both views real explanation, then make clear which one you find more convincing and why.

3.3 Useful Language

Function	Phrases
Introducing a view	On the one hand... / Advocates of this view argue that... / Proponents believe...
Introducing the other view	On the other hand... / Others, however, contend that... / Critics point out that...
Giving your opinion	Having considered both sides, I would argue that... / Personally, I find the second view more convincing because...

MODEL ESSAY 1

Some people think that the government should provide free healthcare for everyone, while others believe individuals should pay for their own healthcare. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Healthcare funding is a contentious issue, with opinion divided between those who favour a fully state-funded system and those who believe individuals should bear the cost themselves. This essay will examine both perspectives before explaining why I lean towards the former.

On the one hand, supporters of private, individually funded healthcare argue that it encourages personal responsibility and reduces pressure on public budgets. When people pay directly for treatment, they may be more inclined to maintain a healthy lifestyle to avoid costs, and private hospitals are often able to offer shorter waiting times because they are not stretched across an entire population.

On the other hand, advocates of free, government-provided healthcare contend that access to medical treatment is a basic human right that should not depend on a person's income. Countries such as the United Kingdom, where the National Health Service provides free treatment at the point of use, demonstrate that a universal system can prevent the situation in which poorer citizens delay seeking treatment for serious conditions simply because they cannot afford it, which ultimately leads to worse health outcomes and higher long-term costs for society.

Having weighed both arguments, I believe that free healthcare funded through taxation is the fairer and more effective option, since good health should not be a privilege reserved for those who can pay for it. In conclusion, although a paid system has some efficiency advantages, a publicly funded model better serves the wellbeing of society as a whole.

MODEL ESSAY 2

Some people believe that children should begin learning a foreign language as soon as they start school, while others think it is better to wait until secondary school. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

There is ongoing debate about the best age for children to begin studying a foreign language, with some favouring an early start and others preferring to wait until secondary education. I will discuss both views before giving my own opinion.

Those in favour of an early start point to research showing that young children's brains are particularly receptive to acquiring new sounds and grammar patterns, which allows them to develop a more natural accent and intuitive grasp of language than older learners. Furthermore, learning a

second language from a young age can broaden a child's cultural awareness at a formative stage of development.

Conversely, those who prefer to delay language learning argue that young children first need to master their mother tongue thoroughly, including reading and writing, before adding the complexity of a second language. They also point out that older students in secondary school have longer attention spans and stronger study skills, meaning they can often progress through grammar and vocabulary more efficiently than young children, despite starting later.

In my opinion, an early start offers clear long-term advantages, particularly for pronunciation and confidence, provided that lessons for young children are kept playful rather than overly academic. In conclusion, while both approaches have merit, I believe primary school is the more effective stage to begin, as long as the teaching method suits the learners' age.

Problem-Solution Essays

Explaining causes or problems, then proposing solutions

4.1 What It Is

You are presented with an issue and asked to identify its causes/problems and suggest solutions — for example, "What problems does this cause, and what solutions can you suggest?" Sometimes only causes, or only problems, are asked for; read the question carefully to see exactly what is required.

4.2 Paragraph Structure

TEMPLATE

Intro: paraphrase the issue + preview that you will discuss causes/problems and solutions

Body 1: problem(s) or cause(s), explained with an example

Body 2: solution(s), explained with an example — ideally solutions that respond directly to the problems in Body 1

Conclusion: summarise the problem and your recommended solution

4.3 Useful Language

Function	Phrases
Stating problems	One of the most pressing problems is... / This gives rise to... / A further consequence is...
Proposing solutions	One effective solution would be to... / This problem could be alleviated by... / Governments should consider...
Linking cause-effect	As a result... / This, in turn, leads to... / Consequently...

MODEL ESSAY 1

Traffic congestion is becoming a serious problem in many major cities around the world. What are the causes of this problem, and what measures can be taken to solve it?

Traffic congestion has become a persistent difficulty in cities worldwide. This essay will examine the main causes of this problem and suggest practical measures that could help resolve it.

The principal cause of urban congestion is the sheer growth in car ownership, driven by rising incomes and the convenience that a private vehicle offers compared with public transport. In addition, many cities were designed decades ago and simply were not built to accommodate today's volume of traffic, meaning that road capacity has failed to keep pace with demand. Poorly synchronised traffic lights and roadworks further compound delays during peak hours.

To address this problem, city authorities could invest more heavily in efficient, affordable public transport systems, such as extended metro networks and dedicated bus lanes, giving commuters a genuinely attractive alternative to driving. Congestion charges, similar to the scheme introduced in London, have also proven effective by discouraging unnecessary car journeys into city centres during busy periods, while the revenue generated can be reinvested in public transport infrastructure. Encouraging remote working where possible would further reduce the number of vehicles on the road during rush hour.

In conclusion, traffic congestion stems mainly from rising car ownership and outdated infrastructure, but a combination of improved public transport, congestion pricing and flexible working arrangements could substantially ease the problem.

MODEL ESSAY 2

An increasing number of young people are struggling to find employment after graduation. What are the reasons for this, and what solutions can be suggested?

Graduate unemployment has risen noticeably in many countries in recent years. This essay will explore the reasons behind this trend and propose some possible solutions.

One major reason is the mismatch between the skills taught in universities and those actually required by employers. Many degree programmes remain heavily theoretical, leaving graduates with limited practical experience in areas such as data analysis or project management that companies increasingly expect. At the same time, the number of university graduates has grown faster than the number of suitable graduate-level jobs, intensifying competition for each available position.

A practical solution would be for universities to integrate compulsory internships or industry placements into their courses, ensuring that students graduate with hands-on experience alongside their academic qualifications. Closer collaboration between universities and businesses in designing curricula would also help ensure that what is taught genuinely reflects current market needs. In addition, governments could support graduate employment through incentive schemes, such as tax

breaks for companies that hire and train recent graduates, thereby encouraging firms to invest in younger workers rather than only seeking experienced candidates.

In conclusion, graduate unemployment largely results from a gap between academic training and workplace demands, but stronger links between education, industry and government could go a long way towards closing that gap.

Advantages & Disadvantages Essays

Weighing the benefits and drawbacks of a trend or practice

5.1 What It Is

You are asked to discuss the advantages and disadvantages of a trend, practice or development. Sometimes the question also asks whether you think the advantages outweigh the disadvantages — check carefully, as this changes whether you need a personal opinion.

5.2 Paragraph Structure

TEMPLATE

Intro: paraphrase the topic + preview that you will discuss advantages and disadvantages (add your opinion here if the question asks for one)

Body 1: advantage(s), explained with an example

Body 2: disadvantage(s), explained with an example

Conclusion: summarise both sides / state which outweighs the other if asked

5.3 Useful Language

Function	Phrases
Advantages	One major benefit of... is... / This offers the advantage of... / A further positive aspect is...
Disadvantages	However, a significant drawback is... / This can also lead to... / On the negative side...
Weighing up	Despite these benefits... / While there are clear advantages, the drawbacks should not be overlooked...

MODEL ESSAY 1

More and more people are choosing to work from home rather than in a traditional office. What are the advantages and disadvantages of this trend?

Remote working has grown considerably in recent years, offering both notable benefits and certain drawbacks for employees and employers alike.

A key advantage of working from home is the improved flexibility it offers. Employees can structure their day around personal commitments, such as childcare or exercise, which often leads to better work-life balance and, in many cases, higher job satisfaction and productivity. Employers, meanwhile, can reduce overhead costs such as office rent and utilities, savings which can then be reinvested into the business or passed on to staff through higher salaries.

However, remote working also carries real disadvantages. Many employees report feeling isolated without the daily social interaction that an office provides, which can negatively affect mental wellbeing and reduce a sense of team cohesion over time. Communication can also become less efficient, as spontaneous discussions that would naturally happen in an office often require scheduled video calls instead, sometimes slowing down decision-making and creative collaboration between colleagues.

In conclusion, while working from home offers valuable flexibility and cost savings, it can also lead to isolation and communication challenges, meaning that a hybrid approach may ultimately offer the best balance for many organisations.

MODEL ESSAY 2

Nowadays, many students choose to study abroad rather than in their home country. What are the advantages and disadvantages of this?

Studying overseas has become an increasingly popular choice among students, bringing with it a distinct set of advantages and disadvantages.

One clear advantage is the exposure to a new culture and language, which broadens students' worldview and develops skills such as independence and adaptability that are highly valued by future employers. In addition, many overseas institutions have strong international reputations, and a degree from such an institution can open doors to global career opportunities that might otherwise be unavailable.

On the other hand, studying abroad presents significant challenges. The financial cost, including tuition fees, accommodation and travel, is often considerably higher than studying locally, placing a heavy burden on students and their families. Furthermore, being far from family and familiar support networks can lead to homesickness and stress, particularly during the initial period of adjustment to a new country, language and academic system.

In conclusion, although studying abroad offers valuable cultural exposure and career advantages, the financial cost and emotional challenges of living far from home mean that it is not the right choice for

every student.

Two-Part (Direct Question) Essays

Answering two related questions in one essay

6.1 What It Is

You are asked two direct, related questions about a topic, such as "Why is this happening?" and "Is this a positive or negative development?" Each body paragraph should answer one question directly and fully.

6.2 Paragraph Structure

TEMPLATE

Intro: paraphrase the topic + briefly preview your answer to both questions

Body 1: full answer to Question 1, explained with an example

Body 2: full answer to Question 2, explained with an example

Conclusion: summarise both answers briefly

COMMON MISTAKE

Do not answer only one of the two questions — examiners specifically check that both parts are addressed for a good Task Response score.

6.3 Useful Language

Function	Phrases
Answering "why"	There are several reasons for this. / This trend can largely be explained by...
Answering "positive/negative"	I would argue that this is a largely positive development because... / This is, on balance, a negative trend, given that...

MODEL ESSAY 1

Many museums and historical sites are mainly visited by tourists rather than local people. Why do you think this is the case? What can be done to encourage local people to visit these places?

It is often observed that museums and historical landmarks attract far more tourists than residents of the surrounding area. This essay will explain why this happens and suggest ways to encourage greater local participation.

One major reason is that local people often take such attractions for granted simply because they are always available nearby, and therefore feel no urgency to visit, unlike tourists whose trip is time-limited. In addition, entry fees, though modest for foreign visitors converting from stronger currencies, can feel expensive to local residents on a domestic income, discouraging repeat or casual visits.

To address this, museums could offer discounted or free entry for local residents, particularly on specific days of the week, removing the financial barrier that discourages regular visits. Running special events, such as evening exhibitions, workshops or talks aimed specifically at the local community, would also help reframe these sites as living, relevant spaces rather than fixed tourist attractions, encouraging residents to see them as somewhere worth returning to rather than a one-time destination reserved for visitors.

In conclusion, local disengagement from museums largely stems from familiarity and cost, but targeted pricing and community-focused events could meaningfully increase local visitor numbers.

MODEL ESSAY 2

Some people spend their entire lives in one place, while others move to different places throughout their lives. Why do some people prefer to move? Is it a positive or negative development?

While some individuals remain in the same location for their whole lives, others relocate frequently. This essay will consider why some people choose to move and whether this is, overall, a positive development.

People often move in pursuit of better career opportunities, particularly as globalisation has made it far easier to work in a different city or country than in previous generations. Others relocate for education, to be near family, or simply out of a desire for new experiences and personal growth that staying in one place cannot provide.

In my view, this trend is largely positive. Moving to a new place often exposes individuals to different cultures, ideas and ways of life, fostering greater adaptability, open-mindedness and resilience. Furthermore, on a practical level, frequent relocation allows people to pursue opportunities that best match their evolving skills and ambitions, rather than being limited to whatever is available locally, which can lead to greater career satisfaction and personal fulfilment over the course of a lifetime.

In conclusion, although moving frequently can be challenging, particularly in terms of building lasting relationships, I believe the opportunities for growth and career development it provides make it, on balance, a positive development.

Linking Words & Cohesive Devices Bank

Boost your Coherence & Cohesion score

Adding Ideas

Furthermore	Moreover	In addition	What is more
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Contrasting Ideas

However	Nevertheless	On the other hand	Despite this
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Cause and Effect

As a result	Consequently	This leads to	Owing to
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Giving Examples

For instance	For example	A case in point is	This is illustrated by
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Sequencing

Firstly / Secondly	To begin with	Finally	Above all
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Summarising / Concluding

In conclusion	To sum up	Overall	Taking everything into account
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WARNING

Do not overuse linking words. One or two per paragraph, placed naturally, is far more effective — and scores higher — than starting every sentence with a connector.

Common Mistakes & Band-9 Upgrades

What separates Band 6 from Band 8–9

8.1 Frequent Mistakes

- **No clear position** — the examiner cannot tell what you actually think.
- **Memorised phrases** — pre-learned sentences that do not quite fit the question, which examiners notice immediately.
- **Ideas without development** — a point is stated but never explained or supported with an example.
- **Repetitive vocabulary** — using the same word (e.g. "important") many times instead of varying language.
- **Weak paragraphing** — one long block of text instead of clearly separated paragraphs.
- **Under 250 words** — an automatic penalty regardless of quality.

8.2 Band 6 → Band 9 Upgrades

Band 6 Sentence	Band 9 Upgrade
"This is a very important problem."	"This is a pressing issue that demands urgent attention."
"I think this is good."	"I would argue that this development is, on balance, beneficial."
"There are many reasons."	"Several interrelated factors help to explain this trend."
"It can help people."	"It can significantly improve individuals' quality of life."

GRAMMAR RANGE

Mix simple sentences with complex ones using relative clauses ("..., which..."), conditionals ("If governments were to invest..."), and passive voice ("Considerable investment is required...") to demonstrate range — but never at the cost of accuracy.

Final Checklist Before You Submit

A 60-second review before time runs out

Task Response

- ✓ I have fully answered every part of the question.
- ✓ My position is clear from the introduction to the conclusion.
- ✓ Every main idea is explained and supported with an example.

Coherence & Cohesion

- ✓ My essay has clear paragraphs (intro, 2 body paragraphs, conclusion).
- ✓ Each paragraph has one main idea, introduced by a topic sentence.
- ✓ Linking words are used naturally, not repeated mechanically.

Lexical Resource

- ✓ I have avoided repeating the same key words too often.
- ✓ I have used topic-specific vocabulary accurately.
- ✓ I have not used any memorised phrase that does not truly fit the question.

Grammatical Range & Accuracy

- ✓ I have used a mix of simple and complex sentences.
- ✓ I have checked verb tenses and subject-verb agreement.
- ✓ My essay is at least 250 words.

EMERALD LAB — FINAL WORD

Consistency beats memorisation. Practise one essay of each type from this book every week, always under 40-minute exam conditions, and compare your work honestly against the model essays. Real progress in IELTS Writing comes from repeated, timed practice — not from reading alone.